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Author(s): E. D. Edwards and C. O. Blagden

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A Chinese Vocabulary of Malacca Malay Words and Phrases collected between A.D. 1403 and 1511 (?)

Transcribed, translated, and edited by E. D. EDWARDS and

C. O. BLAGDEN

THE list of words and phrases contained in this article is one of ten manuscript vocabularies bound up in a volume lettered *Kō Kwō Yī Yü* which forms part of the collection of Chinese books made by the well-known missionary, Morrison (who lived from 1782–1834), and has been deposited on permanent loan by University College, London, in the Library of the School of Oriental Studies.

All its contents are in Chinese characters, some of which are used in their proper senses to indicate the meanings, and others to serve as phonetic transcriptions, of the foreign words explained. Owing to the limitations of the Chinese phonetic system, these transcriptions are often imperfect and ambiguous, and that is one source of uncertainty in the identification of the Malay words in the list here published. Another is that the Chinese collector and his informants may sometimes have misunderstood each other, and the former may have misheard a word given to him even if it was the right one. Besides all this, there may also have been mistakes made by copyists.

For the manuscript is not an original. The colophon says that it was revised, and the reviser may well have added a few errors of his own. Certainly someone did. From internal evidence it seems probable that the words and phrases, or at any rate some of them, were collected half a century or more before the list was revised. The earliest historical date connected with Malacca is 1403, when a mission was sent from China to visit it and open up diplomatic relations. That mission returned to China in 1405, and the record of it contains the earliest certain mention of the existence of Malacca that is known to us; nor is there any clear indication as to how long the place may have been in existence before that time. In 1511 it was conquered by the Portuguese, and the Malay Sultan and chiefs, together with a considerable part of the Malay population, fled and abandoned it.

But in Parts VIII, IX, and XIV of our vocabulary there are words and phrases which seem to imply the existence of a Malay government. Moreover, in the whole vocabulary no European loanwords at all have been found; and there would almost inevitably have been

some if any considerable part of it had been made after the time of the Portuguese conquest.

It appears to be practically certain, therefore, that the vocabulary was compiled from lists of words collected within the period indicated above, and that it is the oldest Malay vocabulary known to us, the next oldest being the one made by Pigafetta in 1521.

That it was derived from several different sources is made highly probable by the fact that the same word is often transcribed in quite distinct ways, sometimes even in the same section (cf. 61 (with 67-9), 73-4, and 89-90 ; 63 (with 208), 64 (with 195), and 79-82 ; 192 and 206 ; 212 (with 433), 216 and 434 ; 278 and 469 ; 284 and 384). From the number of such cases it may reasonably be inferred that several independent collectors had been at work, and that their various word lists were afterwards consolidated into one and roughly subdivided into parts by a compiler, possibly by the reviser who added the colophon in the middle of the sixteenth century.

Owing to the peculiarities of Chinese transcription the vocabulary can teach us very little about the phonetics of the fifteenth century Malay. Nor does it give us much new material for Malay lexicography. This is hardly surprising when one considers how extraordinarily conservative the language has shown itself to be in these respects. In the Sumatran inscriptions of Śrī Vijaya dating from A.D. 683-6, there are numerous words that are absolutely identical with their modern forms. (Cf. the vocabulary in *BEFEO*. xxx, 65-80.)

Nevertheless, it seemed worth while to rescue this old vocabulary from the obscurity in which it has rested so long. Malay documents older than the seventeenth century are decidedly rare, and very little indeed has come down to us from still earlier times ; so that anything that can be discovered has a certain value. Besides, this document tells us something about the things that interested the Chinese collectors. Most of the words contained in it are substantives (and principally the names of things) ; then come adjectives ; verbs are poorly represented, and other parts of speech are almost entirely wanting.

The greater part of the 482 entries could be identified at first sight. But others were not so obvious, and a few have resisted our best efforts. It is to be hoped, therefore, that other scholars will be more successful in dealing with them. When the Malay equivalents were not found in the usual dictionaries (such as those of Favre, Wilkinson, and Winstedt) an authority for them has been given,

unless, being loanwords, they are recorded in the ordinary dictionaries of the languages from which they were borrowed. Not all loanwords have been noted as being such, particularly when they are in common use in Malay; and they are generally given in their Malay, not their original foreign, forms. The titles of certain works of reference are given at the end of this paper. For the explanation of some of the botanical names we are also specially indebted to the personal assistance of Mr. H. N. Ridley, C.M.G.

It might have been expected that the Chinese transcription would indicate what kind of Chinese the collector used as a basis. But an examination shows that no single systematic method was in use, which confirms the conclusion already indicated above that several collectors, each with his own method, have been at work. The latitude they allowed themselves may be illustrated, for example, by the use of the character *chên*, which does duty for the Malay sounds *chên*, *chêng*, *jě(r)*, *jêng*, *ching*, and *chin*.

Accordingly the romanization adopted has been that of Pekinese, as found in Giles's dictionary, which though under the circumstances often conventional, has at least the merit of uniformity and facilitates reference. For the Malay, the ordinary system of romanization used by English scholars has been followed.

A literal translation of the Chinese catchwords has been given in most cases, in order to assist in determining the Malay equivalents.

For convenience of reference the entries have been numbered and an asterisk has been added to those which are discussed in the notes, such notes being numbered identically. In certain cases, where the reference is to another number, the latter has been added to the asterisk.

It is rather remarkable that Malay is not one of the languages recorded by Hirth in his article mentioned at the end of this paper, as having been officially studied during the period at which this vocabulary was compiled. Yet from internal evidence it seems likely that it was in fact compiled under official auspices, and *a priori* that would seem most probable. A Chinese-Japanese vocabulary, bound up in the same volume as our Chinese-Malay one, has a colophon indicating that it was revised in the same year, though not by the same person.